

End-to-end guide for how questions are grouped, answered, and shown back to students on **Track my answer**.

1. Ask Desk — student consent

When a student submits a question they choose:

Field	Values	Effect
Anonymous publication consent	Yes / No	Yes → question may enter the merge pool. No → individual-only path; never clustered.
Follow-up consent	Yes / No	Used for in-person mentor selection; does not affect merge.

Only submissions with `consentPublish = Yes` are considered for automatic or manual merging.

2. Curation desk — merge logic

Location: Staff tab → **Curation desk**

2.1 Automatic merge (“Merge questions”)

1. Filter to merge-opted submissions only (`consentPublish = Yes`).
2. **Group by theme + sub-area** (subtheme). “Keep sub-areas separate” is on by default — questions in different subthemes within the same theme are never merged.
3. **Tokenise** each question (+ optional context): lowercase, strip punctuation/diacritics, remove stop words, light stemming (`-ing` , `-ed` , `-s` , `-tion` , `-ment`).
4. **Weighted similarity** (replaces plain Jaccard):
 - Token Jaccard + **bigram overlap** + **rare-term weighting** (terms appearing in ≤ 2 questions in the theme group count 1.5×).
 - Combined score: 55% weighted Jaccard, 35% plain Jaccard, 10% bigram Jaccard.
5. **Pass 1 — strict auto-merge:** each question joins the best bucket only if similarity $\geq$ **threshold** (default **0.42**, slider 0.15–0.70). No match → singleton.
6. **Pass 2 — packing:** buckets under 6 members may combine if cross-bucket similarity $\geq \max(0.28, \text{threshold} \times 0.78)$.
7. **Singletons:** questions with no similar neighbour stay as their own group (`kind: unique`) — mentors still answer them; they are not forced into wrong groups.
8. **Composite wording:** defaults to the **longest member question**; staff edit on Curation desk for hall phrasing.
9. **Re-merge** preserves existing `composite` , `answer` , and cluster IDs when the same representative question is still in a group.

2.2 Manual controls

Action	How
Merge groups	Tick ≥2 group checkboxes → Merge selected groups . Member lists combine; longest representative wording is kept.
Split one student out	Open a group → Split out next to their wording. They become a new singleton cluster.
Edit composite	Write the hall question mentors will answer (shown on Track and Answer board).
Assign mentor / status	Track workflow: New → Composed → Sent to mentor → Answered → Published.
Publish	Publish to students makes the merged answer visible on the public Answer board (requires answer text). Excel import auto-sets status to Published.

2.3 Threshold tuning (staff)

Slider	Effect
Lower (e.g. 0.25)	Fewer, broader groups — more questions lumped together.
Higher (e.g. 0.55)	More, tighter groups — only very similar wording merges.
Uncheck “Keep sub-areas separate”	Merge across subthemes within a theme (use with care).

3. Mentor pack — merged groups only

Location: Staff tab → **Mentor pack**

The mentor pack handles **merge-opted students only** (merged and unique singleton groups). Students who opted **No** at the Ask Desk are **not** in the mentor pack — answer them from **Insights → Briefing board → Provide answer**.

3.1 Download merged Excel (MENTOR_BRIEF)

One row per student in each cluster. Cluster-level columns repeat on every member row.

Column	Purpose
Cluster_ID	Stable group id — do not edit
Theme , Subtheme	Classification
Students_In_Cluster	Group size
Composite_Question	Hall question mentors answer
Representative_Wording	Longest raw student wording
Ticket_ID	Student ticket
Question_ID	Internal id
Delegate_No	WAC delegate number
Name , Email	For mentor reference (staff export only)
Original_Question	That student's exact wording
MERGED_ANSWER	Fill — hall answer for the whole group
INDIVIDUAL_ANSWER	Optional — personal note for this ticket only (merge-opted students)
ACTION_1 – ACTION_3	Next steps (merged answer)
COMMON_MISTAKE	One pitfall
RESOURCE_1 , RESOURCE_2	Official links/refs
MENTOR_NAME_DESIGNATION	Sign-off
Assigned_Mentor	Pre-filled from curation desk

A second sheet **HOW_TO_FILL** explains the columns.

3.2 Upload filled merged answer sheet

Same section as download — **Upload filled merged answer sheet** button.

- Matches rows by Cluster_ID .
- Reads MERGED_ANSWER (or legacy ANSWER) → saved on cluster → visible to **all merge-opted members** on Track.
- Reads optional INDIVIDUAL_ANSWER per Ticket_ID → saved as individualAnswer on that submission.
- Sets cluster status: Published when a merged answer is imported.
- Success notice shows counts; students see answers on **Track my answer** by ticket.

3.3 Word brief & submission register

- **Word brief** — printable one-page-per-cluster summary for mentors without Excel.
- **Full submission register** — audit export of every submission with cluster assignment.

4. Individual answers — Insights briefing board only

Location: Staff tab → **Insights** → Briefing board → **Provide answer**

- For students who opted **No** at the Ask Desk (never merged).

- Also works for merge-opted students who need a **personal note** in addition to the hall answer.
- Saves via `answerIndividual` API → `individualAnswer` on the submission record in Firestore.
- For merge-opted students the **hall** lane still comes from the cluster / `MERGED_ANSWER` import in the mentor pack.
- Track applies the dual-answer rules in section 5.

There is **no** separate `INDIVIDUAL_BRIEF` download/upload in the mentor pack.

5. What students see (Track my answer)

Student type	Merged answer	Individual answer	UX
Opted Yes to merge	✓	✓	Both blocks, clearly labelled
Opted Yes	✓	—	Hall answer + “Personal note coming soon”
Opted Yes	—	✓	Personal answer + “Hall answer coming soon”
Opted Yes	—	—	“Grouped with N others...” status
Opted No	—	✓	Mentor answer only (no merge messaging)
Opted No	—	—	“Received — with the desk”

6. What works today vs known gaps

Works today

- Firestore-backed store (`/api/aym-store`) for questions, clusters, individual answers.
- Consent-gated merge pool.
- Theme + subtheme grouping (default).
- Two-pass weighted similarity clustering with packing toward ~6–7 members.
- Manual merge / split.
- Per-member Excel export with merged answer columns.
- Merged answer upload in mentor pack (same section as download).
- Track dual-answer UX for merge-opted students.
- Insights individual answer → Track (sole path for opt-out students).
- Public Answer board for published cluster answers.

Gaps / limitations

- **Similarity is lexical only** — paraphrases with different words may not merge (see future enhancements).
- **No merge audit log** — who merged/split and when is not recorded.
- **No async job queue** — re-merge on 500+ questions runs in the browser; may feel slow.
- **Email lookup on Track** requires delegate session or staff; ticket lookup is public.
- **Board vs Track** — Answer board shows published **cluster** answers only, not personal notes.
- **Variant cap** — UI stores up to 3 variant wordings per cluster (Excel export lists every member).

7. Future enhancements (recommendations)

Priority	Enhancement	Why
High	Embedding similarity (e.g. small multilingual model)	Catch paraphrased questions Jaccard misses.
High	Server-side merge job	Scale beyond browser timeout; retry + progress bar.
Medium	Audit log	<code>merged_by</code> , <code>split_at</code> , import batch id for accountability.
Medium	Confidence score	Show staff "87% similar" before auto-merge.
Medium	Queue dashboard	Unclustered / uncomposed / awaiting mentor counts by theme.
Low	Student notification	Email/SMS when answer lands on Track.
Low	Versioned answers	Edit history if mentor revises guidance.

8. Quick staff checklist

1. **Merge questions** on Curation desk (tune threshold if groups look wrong; default 0.42).
2. **Write composite** wording for each group.
3. **Export Excel** from Mentor pack (filter by theme if needed).
4. Mentors fill **MERGED_ANSWER** (+ optional **INDIVIDUAL_ANSWER** per row for personal notes).
5. **Upload filled merged sheet** in mentor pack → verify counts in success notice.
6. Spot-check on **Track my answer** with a sample ticket.
7. Use **Insights** → **Provide answer** for opt-out students and one-off personal replies.
8. **Publish** on Curation desk if answers should appear on the public Answer board (import auto-publishes).

Last updated: August 2026 — ayurmarg-preview